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Abstract

This paper is a brief but critical survey of some theories of organizational culture. It outlines the theories of culture borrowed from anthropology by social scientists interested in 'complex organizations', and locates these theories in an historical debate regarding their 'proper' use. The paper argues the need for a conceptual distinction between culture and social structure, and asserts that the culture of organizational life cannot be analyzed in terms of a universal unitary concept. The argument concludes by suggesting 'conceptual tools' for interpreting culture — symbol, ideational systems, myth and ritual — and how they might be used in analysis.

Introduction

The study of organizational culture — the proposition that organizations create myths and legends, engage in rites and rituals, and are governed through shared symbols and customs — is much in vogue. Although the reasons for this are not entirely clear, two issues deserve mention: (1) the effect of political, ideological and socio-economic factors on social theory; (2) the related issue of the scholarly and ideological implications of the selective borrowing of key concepts from one discipline by other fields of study.

The present preoccupation with organizational culture is probably related to socio-economic factors in Western society. Most Western countries have experienced a dramatic downturn in their economies. This, in turn, has helped to emphasize the structural inequalities inherent in these societies and has placed the structure of western capitalism under severe pressure. It probably is no accident that many scholars are emphasizing cultural problems — particularly where cultural problems are naively operationalized in terms of 'people problems' — at a time when the structures of many Western institutions are under strain.

Some social theorists use the term 'culture' to embrace all that is human within the organization. They emphasize culture, either consciously or unconsciously, in such a way as to blur or hide problems and contradictions inherent in the social structure. Of course, both an organization's culture and its structure are socially created; but that is not what is at issue here. The problem with some studies of organizational culture is that they appear to presume that there exists

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in a real and tangible sense a collective organizational culture that can be created, measured and manipulated in order to enhance organizational effectiveness. The link between 'culture' and 'effectiveness' has become, recently, quite pronounced, and studies incorporating in their title such phrases as the 'culture of school effectiveness', or the 'culture of corporate effectiveness' abound. It is implied that an ineffective organization can be made effective — a school can produce the 'model citizen', that is, one who can find employment, and the corporation can enhance its profit margin — if an unhealthy organizational culture can be supplanted with a healthy one. The problem is one of changing people's values, norms and attitudes so that they make the 'right' and necessary contribution to the healthy collective 'culture' despite (or in ignorance of) any inherent conflict of individual and group interest or the way in which power, authority and control are structured in the organization.

Areas of study, such as the study of complex organizations — including educational and corporate administration, management studies, and human relations and interpersonal dynamics — are influenced by concepts that filter down into the ranks of their practitioners from older, well-founded disciplines. The idea of culture in organizations is a concept borrowed mostly from anthropology, although some sociologists, such as Durkheim, have also been influential.

There is nothing wrong with one discipline borrowing concepts from another discipline; this process has resulted in important theoretical innovations. However, there is a danger that, when one area of study borrows key concepts from other disciplines, the concepts become either stereotyped or distorted in the transfer. Also, when concepts are borrowed from other disciplines, they may not be borrowed *in toto*: that is, rather than accepting an entire 'package' — which may include the historical debates surrounding the 'proper' uses of the concepts — people only select aspects of the concepts that suit their interests and thinking at a particular time. This may result either in a slanted and biased application of the concepts or a dilution of their original analytical power.

The concept of organizational culture can be a powerful analytical tool in the analysis and interpretation of human action within complex organizations. Alternatively, it can be misused to reify the social reality of organizational life. It may be timely to have a close look at some of the ways in which the concept of 'culture' has been used in organizational research, paying particular attention to questions concerning what aspects of the concept of culture have been borrowed from anthropology and, to a lesser extent, sociology. It seems that much of the use of culture as a unitary concept expressing, on the one hand, social cohesion and integration, and on the other, organizational effectiveness, is the result of the transfer of the concept of culture to organizational analysis from a particular anthropological and sociological theoretical tradition, i.e., the 'structural-functional' theoretical paradigm.

Organizational culture is a difficult but seminal concept, and a single paper could neither do justice to all facets of the concept, nor could it analyze all the

ways in which it has been employed in empirical research. There is a growing body of literature that critically assesses the study of organizational culture, and it is likely that the debate surrounding the 'proper' use of the concept of culture in organizational analysis will continue for some time (see, in particular, Allaire and Firsirotu 1984; Gregory 1983; Smircich 1983). This paper contributes to the debate in three limited ways. First, it briefly reviews a few of the consequences of the selective borrowing of the concept of culture. The purpose here is not to debunk past studies of organizational culture, but to attempt to illustrate some of the political and ideological as well as the scholarly effects of viewing culture from a particular theoretical perspective. The paper then attempts to disentangle the subtle difference between an organization's culture and its social structure. The paper concludes with a brief discussion of some 'sub-concepts' that comprise the idea of culture. Culture, as a total concept, is too all embracing. It needs to be dissected into manageable proportions so that it can be used in the interpretation of observed behaviour.

The Concept Borrowed

Some recent studies of organizational or corporate culture have been undertaken by what Turner (1986), drawing on Ott's (1984) terminology, calls 'pop cultural magicians', 'tricksters' who make their living by convincing North American and European corporate executives that they can equal the productivity of Japanese industry through the mechanical manipulation of organizational symbols, myths and customs. Such studies are not much concerned with theory of any sort, but seize upon fads in the realm of ideas. However, many 'honest grapplers' (Turner 1986) in their approach to corporate culture have produced studies that also seem unduly linked to the interest of management and which promulgate the idea that 'culture' is the collective consciousness of the organization, 'owned' by management and available to management for manipulation. An attempt will be made to illustrate the effects of these weaknesses on the study of corporate culture, not by questioning the integrity of individual researchers, but through examining the theoretical basis on which the idea of corporate culture rests. The argument will explore three interrelated themes:

1. organizational theorists — particularly, though not exclusively, those belonging to the human relations and related schools — have not considered the multiplicity of theories of culture, but have borrowed the concept of culture from only one anthropological tradition: structural-functionalism;
2. although theories of organizational or corporate culture have their 'roots' in structural-functionalism, they have also 'mutated' in the process of application;
3. the equating of corporate culture with a 'natural' force for social integration within the organization — with a unitary organizational collective

consciousness that can both be measured and manipulated — seems to flow from the structural–functional tradition from which the concept is borrowed.

Nearly twenty-five years ago, van der Berghe (1963) criticized structural–functional theory for its reliance on a biological metaphor, for its positivistic stance, for its insistence that social order is created and maintained through individuals internalizing dominant social norms and values, for its treatment of people holding alternative norms and values as being socially deviant, and for its assumption that the parts of a society exist in a natural state of equilibrium, functioning efficiently so as to maintain the effectiveness of the total social structure (also see Rex 1961; Friedrichs 1970; and Gouldner 1970, 1973). Although, sometimes, it is not realized that rather old arguments are being repeated, similar criticisms are being applied to studies of corporate culture. However, the purpose of this essay is not to ground contemporary criticisms of corporate culture studies in past criticisms of structural–functionalism. Rather, the intention is to illustrate how studies of corporate culture, because of the structural–functional theoretical legacy, tend to ignore or gloss over inherent conflicts and important structural features of the organization, particularly the structure of power and conflict, structured inequality and the significance of the structure of ‘class cultures’ (see Turner 1986). Later in the paper, an attempt will be made to build the concept of structure and conflict back into a theory of corporate culture.

The structural–functional theoretical framework has had a profound influence on all aspects of the study of complex organizations (Silverman 1970). Its influence on the concept of organizational culture is particularly notable, which is not surprising since ‘structural-functional’ theory has its roots in the development of British social anthropology in the 1920s’ 30s and 40s (Kuper 1973). While Talcott Parsons transported structural–functionalism across the Atlantic, the British social anthropologists — themselves influenced by the French sociologist Emile Durkheim — gave birth to the theory. Out of the many conceptualizations of culture available, social theorists have been prone to seize — sometimes somewhat uncritically — upon Durkheim’s idea of the collective consciousness and upon Radcliffe-Brown’s notion that ‘cultural patterns are crystallized in social structure “as institutionalized and standardized modes of behaviour and thought whose normal forms are socially recognized in the explicit or implicit rules to which members of a society tend to conform”’ (Keesing 1974: 83). Several studies of organizational culture seem to assume that ‘culture’ is a unifying force within the organization, that there exists a universal homogeneous culture, and that the task for the researcher is to discover it. A few examples will help illustrate the point.

Kilmann (1982: 11) refers to culture as ‘the collective will of members’; it is ‘what the corporation *really wants* or what *really counts* in order to get ahead’. According to Schwartz and Davis (1981: 33) culture is ‘a pattern of beliefs and expectations shared by the organization’s members’ that create ‘norms that powerfully shape the behaviour of individuals and groups in the organization’.

Kilmann et al. (1985a: 2) claim that their edited book *Gaining control of the corporate culture* represents the ‘“state of the art” of corporate culture’ and that the contributors are ‘those who are at the leading edge of this topic’. Chapter after chapter, definitions of culture are provided that stress the internalization of norms, social integration and stability, that link culture firmly with the interests of management, and that treat culture as the collective will or consciousness of the organization. In the Preface, the editors define culture as the ‘invisible force behind the tangibles and observables in any organization. . . . Culture is to the organization what personality is to the individual’ (1985a: ix). In the Introduction they state that ‘culture can be defined as the shared philosophies, ideologies, values, assumptions, beliefs, expectations, attitudes, and norms that knit a community together’ (1985a: 5). In Chapter Two, Schein (1985a: 17) argues that ‘“strong” cultures are somehow more likely to be associated with effectiveness than are “weak” cultures, and that strong cultures can be deliberately created’. In another chapter, Sapienza (1985: 66–67) states that ‘one of the most important facets of organizational culture is the system of *shared beliefs*’. Lorsch (1985: 84) takes culture to mean ‘the beliefs top managers in a company share about how they should manage themselves and other employees’. Gordon (1985: 104) chooses to study culture through an ‘upper-level group because we believe that the corporate values held by management are reflected in behaviour throughout an organization’. Davis (1985: 138) states that ‘corporate culture is the pattern of shared beliefs and values that shapes the meaning of an institution for its members and provides them with the rules for behaviour’. According to Martin (1985: 148) ‘in many organizations, corporate cultures are developed from the philosophies of top management and maintained through the acceptance of these philosophies by the organization’s members’. Sathe (1985: 255) sees culture as ‘those beliefs and values people consider to be their own; that is, those they have *internalized*’. Allen (1985: 334) firmly links culture with the internalization of norms, with:

‘norms encompass[ing] all behaviour that is expected, accepted, or supported by the group, whether that behaviour is stated or unstated. The norm is the sanctioned behaviour, and people are rewarded and encouraged when they follow the norms, and chastised, confronted, and ostracized when they violate them.’

Those who deviate from the dominant norms are either to be resocialized or excluded from the organization. According to Kilmann et al. culture is a ‘controllable variable’, and ‘managing corporate cultures is now possible’ (1985b: 423, 431), and for Kilmann (1985: 351), ‘to understand the essence or soul of the organization requires that we travel below the charts, rulebooks, machines, and buildings into the underground world of corporate cultures’.

Gaining control of the corporate culture contains interesting and valuable information on aspects of the operation of various corporations, but except for one or two chapters, the theories of culture used by the contributors rest on the

premise that the norms, values and beliefs of organizational members are factors that create consensus, predict behaviour and create unity. This leads to conclusions that are little more than statements about managements' responsibility to reward positive behaviour and attitudes, to foster the self-esteem and self-confidence of organizations' members, to encourage allegiance to organizational goals and missions, to inform members of the need for change when it arises, and to create a feeling of *esprit de corps* within the organization. If the book represents the 'state-of-the-art' of corporate culture studies, then it is a state-of-the-art based on a very narrow conceptualization of the idea of culture. The degree to which norms, for example, are internalized and create integrated and stable structures, is, first of all, an empirical question, not something to be assumed through theory. Culture, if it is to have any meaning, needs to be related to the total organization, not regarded as phenomena solely vested in the hands of management. The idea that culture is the collective will of the organization — its personality, an invisible force or the organization's soul — is a metaphysical explanation of behaviour and events that are impossible to observe. Any theory that assumes that culture is the internalization of dominant norms and values, must also assume that all members must hold to the dominant value system or else be 'outside culture'. Of course, such a stance flies-in-the-face of reality, particularly when we consider organizations where management tends to belong to one social class and workers to another. In such organizations, values, norms and social meanings are structured by 'class cultures' and are a constant potential source for dispute, with strikes only one example where such disputes become overt conflicts. For example, it would be difficult to explain the 1984 strike of the British coal miners either in terms of the collective will of the corporation or in terms of the internalization of dominant norms and values. As will be discussed later, norms and values have as much potential for creating conflict within organizations as they do for creating social cohesion.

It should be noted that just because organizational theorists may have borrowed the concept of culture from a certain social anthropological tradition, it does not necessarily mean that organizational theorists use the concept of culture in exactly the same way as would social anthropologists. For example, while Radcliffe-Brown and other social anthropologists have treated culture as an integral feature of the structure and function of all societies — relating specific cultures to particular social outcomes — some organizational theorists have been inclined to treat culture as either exotic or 'irrational' behaviour (Kanter 1977). More importantly, several studies of organizational culture have moved the concept of culture beyond that of a unifying and regulatory mechanism towards it being a form of social control created and manipulated by management. Baker (1980), for example, writes about 'managing organizational culture' and Allen and Kraft (1982) attempt to illustrate 'how to create the corporate culture you want and need'. Schein (1985b: 2) maintains that 'organizational cultures are created by leaders, and one of the most decisive functions of leadership may well be the creation, the management, and — if

and when that may become necessary — the destruction of culture'. According to Schein (1985b: 2) 'we must recognize the centrality of this culture management function in the leadership concept'.

Most anthropologists would find the idea that leaders create culture preposterous: leaders do not create culture, it emerges from the collective social interaction of groups and communities. It is unlikely that social anthropologists would postulate that tribal leaders create culture; the chief is as much a part of a local culture as are his tribal or clan compatriots. The link between culture, management and control is not solely due to structural–functional theory *per se*. It is also due to the way in which selective aspects of the concept of culture have been borrowed from the structural–functional tradition, coupled with the propensity (either latent or manifest) of this theoretical paradigm to support the notion that culture can be used by leaders to control others in the achievement of organizational goals.

It has often been noted that one of the crucial weaknesses of structural–functional theory is its reliance on a biological metaphor (see, in particular, Nisbet 1969). In accordance with the metaphor, the theory assumes that an organization can be understood as either a huge organism or a 'superindividual'; hence, 'culture' is transferred from the individual actors who create and reproduce it to the organization as a whole. Since it is the organic organization that has 'culture', culture, including members' norms, values and beliefs, is necessarily a mechanism that creates organizational unity: the parts of a healthy organism do not work against themselves.

There are numerous examples, as Allaire and Firsirotu (1984: 194) note, where the organization is endowed with biomorphic and/or anthropomorphic characteristics: it is healthy or unhealthy, goes through a life cycle, and has personality, needs and character (see Rice 1963; Harrison 1972; Argyris and Schon 1978; Aldrich 1979; Kimberly and Miles 1980). Through the use of the anthropomorphic analogy in particular, the organization is transformed into a 'superindividual', and culture becomes the product of the collective consciousness of the organization's members. As mentioned above, the basic criticism of this approach to organizational culture is that it leads to metaphysical explanations for something that is impossible to observe.

The use of organic simile and the idea that culture can be regarded as the collective consciousness of the group are mostly derived from the theories of Durkheim. Although these theories remain in vogue, it is important to note past criticisms:

'The metaphysical concepts of a group mind, collective sensorium or consciousness are due to an apparent antinomy of sociological reality: the psychological nature of human culture on the one hand and on the other the fact that culture transcends the individual. The fallacious solution of this antinomy is the theory that human minds combine or integrate and form a superindividual and yet essentially spiritual being. . . . [S]uch concepts as consciousness of kind or the inevitability of collective imitation, account for the psychological yet superindividual nature of social reality by introducing some theoretical metaphysical short cut. . . .' (Malinowski 1930: 623)

In incorporating the idea of collective consciousness into that of organizational culture many theorists have failed to also incorporate the historical criticisms attached to the original notion.

Individuals create and reproduce culture, but obviously they do not do so in a vacuum. The resources the individual has to draw upon in creating culture are not manufactured by the individual. Language is the classic example: no one person creates language, but we all use language creatively (Giddens 1982). This point will be examined in more detail below.

The human relations school of 'scientific' management deserves special mention for it was the first body of theorists to explore informal social relations in organizations and to take the concept of organizational culture seriously (see Perrow 1979 for a review of the history of the human relations school and see Mayo 1933; Gardner 1945; Warner and Low 1947; Richardson and Walker 1948), but the human relations theorists have approached organizational culture mainly from a behaviourist oriented psychological framework. The language used by human relations theorists is based on a medical/biological metaphor: they speak of healthy and unhealthy organizational culture or climate and talk about organizational hygiene. Human relations theorists regard culture as something which an organization has and which can be manipulated to serve the ends of management. In summarizing past research efforts of the human relations school, Gregory (1983: 361) argues that the school's 'promanagement position resulted in biased research that studied the "irrational" behaviour of lower ranking personnel and supported unquestioningly the "rational manager" model'. Moreover:

'The current corporate culture studies are not substantially different from earlier Human Relations research, in that the goal is still to illustrate the impact of "irrational" human factors on "rational" corporate objectives. "Rational" corporate objectives correspond to management's goals for the organization. Researchers in both areas sought to provide managers with tools to assess and control the organizational culture of their subordinates' (Gregory 1983: 361)

Despite such criticisms, practitioners, as well as academic researchers, have been intent upon discovering what creates 'healthy' and 'unhealthy' organizational culture. Managers of large corporations have come to think that economic success is somehow linked with the type of organizational culture or climate that they create. The idea of corporate culture has been pursued in such popular forms as *Business Week* 1980 and *Fortune Magazine* 1982. Ouchi's (1981) work, and the development of 'Theory Z' linking successful and unsuccessful organizational performance to the type of culture created by American and Japanese companies, has gained great popularity (also see Pascale and Athos 1981). Corporate managers seem to believe that a unifying organizational culture can be created and manipulated, and are prepared to pay good money to back their beliefs: 'the marketing of "corporate culture" is largely underway' (Smircich 1983: 346).

Those intent upon creating a 'healthy' and 'successful' corporate climate are

often blind to 'what is' by their pursuit of 'what should be' (Gregory 1983; Smircich 1983; Allaire and Firsirotu 1984). Corporate success, particularly economic success, is dependent far more upon external environmental influences and the vagaries of the market place than on internal interpersonal dynamics. More importantly, the assumption that a corporate culture can be created so as to unite members for the effective and efficient attainment of corporate goals flies-in-the-face of almost everyone's experience of organizational life. Organizations are often arenas for dispute and conflict, and one of the main items under dispute is often values. Organizations are not one homogeneous culture, but are 'multi-cultural', and culture can be a source of conflict (Gregory 1983). Cultural conflict is most obvious in professional organizations — large teaching hospitals, research laboratories, tertiary education institutions. C. P. Snow's thesis of two cultures manifests itself month after month in every meeting of a university's academic board. Several studies have shown that academics may tend to give greater allegiance to their profession than to their college or university, which may produce conflict between the interest of the individual academic and the interests of those who manage the institution (see, in particular, Gouldner 1958, but see also Meltzer 1956; Merton 1957; Box and Cotgrove 1966; Hind 1971). Unity within organizational sub-cultures (academic departments, for example) can be a source of conflict as the various sub-cultures compete for both scarce resources and prestige.

Nonetheless, human relations and related fields of study, and their preoccupation with the idea of a healthy or successful corporate culture, need to be taken seriously for two reasons. First, there are successful and not-so-successful organizations, and there is something about the successful organization that goes beyond explanations based on superior technology, efficient management and an advantageous position in the market place. There is a certain 'feel' about the successful school, university, or large corporation, and the phenomenon, whatever it is and whatever 'success' may mean, deserves investigation.

Second, while organizations may be regarded as forums for conflict and dispute, they also wield power in modern society through what Galbraith (1983) terms their ability to *condition* their own members and the public at large. Organizations have access to the three primary instruments of power: condign power (physical), compensatory power (economic) and conditioned power (belief). According to Galbraith, conditioned power is the most important in modern industrial society, and organization is the locus of conditioned power. It is through 'persuasion, education, or the social commitment to what seems natural, proper or right' that the corporation, educational institution, church and the state 'cause the individual to submit to the will of another or of others' (Galbraith 1983: 23). Organizations may also enforce their will through the use of physical or economic power. In the past, the church was particularly prone to exercise its power through such means, but conditioned power is central 'to the functioning of the modern economy and

polity, and in capitalist and socialist countries alike' (Galbraith 1983: 23). Thus, it is imperative that we understand the beliefs, symbols, myths, ideologies and folklores — the 'culture' — of the modern organization as a form of social control. It is not a form of social control created and manipulated by management, but a process in which management, workers and the community at large participate alike.

Furthermore, Galbraith (1983) argues that there is a symmetric relationship between how power is exercised and how it is challenged: condign power is met with violence, compensatory power is met with the regulation of the market place, and conditioned power is met with countervailing beliefs and ideologies. Consumer and environmental action groups represent a good example of a symmetric challenge to the conditioned power of modern corporations. In this respect, organizational culture is not a force for social integration, but a phenomenon likely to breed 'counter-cultures'.

An adequate theory of culture needs to be divorced from the direct interests of management and the naive assumption that a 'successful corporate culture' is either 'naturally good and stabilizing' or can be 'consciously manipulated'. Just because group interaction within an organization is based on norms and symbols, it does not necessarily follow that consensus and cohesion, based on shared and internalized value systems, are the result. Hopefully, the structural-functional theoretical assumptions on which the biomorphic, cohesive, integrative and stabilizing characteristics of organizational studies of corporate culture rest have been adequately demonstrated and critiqued, and the need for a theory of culture that more adequately takes account of the contextual richness of social life within the organization as a whole has been illustrated. Before suggesting alternative ways of viewing corporate culture, a few additional words need to be said about the manipulation of culture.

While it is maintained that culture *as a whole* cannot be consciously manipulated by management or any other group, culture is not necessarily static: cultures do change within organizations, and management does have more direct control than other organizational members over certain aspects of the corporate cultures, such as, control over logos and officially stated missions and ethos. In this regard, some scholars have expressed concern that certain organizations can foster an allegiance to a corporate ethos that borders on religious fervour, while the ethos itself is of questionable social value (Turner 1986). The way in which management attempts to intervene in the culture of an organization should be a research priority, particularly in relation to the potential 'conditioned power' of organization. However, empirically assessing the power and ability of management to intervene in the culture of an organization and assuming through theory that management creates, changes and imposes 'culture' on a passive and uncritical membership — that management creates a cultural milieu in which rank-and-file staff are immersed and have no choice but to internalize its embedded norms and values — are quite separate considerations.

If culture emerges from the social interaction of all organizational members (as

is argued here), then the way in which management may attempt to manipulate organizational symbols, myths, customs, etc., must be interpreted in relation to the *total* organizational culture of which management itself is only one part. Hitler did not create Nazi Germany by himself. It may be the case that some organizations are more prone to accept executive control, including control over organizational symbols and meanings, than are other organizations, but again, this is, first of all, an empirical question, not something that can be assumed through theory. Also, power, as Weber maintained, is exercised not merely through its acceptance by others, but rests on having the resources — which flow, at least in part, from one's position in the social structure — to impose one's will on others despite opposition.

While, in practice, questions of power, conflict and culture in the modern organization cannot be divorced, the symbiotic relationship between the phenomena may be more adequately understood if a conceptual distinction is drawn between culture and social structure. We will now look at what consequences such a distinction may have for a theory of organizational or corporate culture.

Towards a Theory of Culture

While the idea of organizational culture has been approached in a variety of ways, the various theories, basically, fall into two camps or schools (Smircich 1983). First, as was argued above, there are those who treat organizational culture as a variable: it is something that an organization has (see Cummings and Schmidt 1972; Schwartz and Davis 1981; Deal and Kennedy 1982; Peters and Waterman 1982). Second, there is the view that 'culture is something an organization is' (Smircich 1983: 347; and see Harris and Cronen 1979; Weick 1979; Morgan 1980; Wacker 1981). The second approach is much more closely aligned to the way in which anthropologists treat culture. Rather than regarding culture as something imported into an organization from the broader society, or as something created by management, these theorists believe that culture is the product of negotiated and shared symbols and meanings; it emerges from social interaction. In this approach to culture, the researcher is not analyzing some 'irrational' or exotic aspect of organizational life. The interpretation of organizational culture must be deeply embedded in the contextual richness of the total social life of organizational members. Culture cannot be treated as being incidental, or outside of, the 'true purpose' of the organization (Gregory 1983).

Treating culture as emerging from social interaction — treating it as something that the organization 'is', rather than treating it as a variable that can be manipulated by management — has obvious research implications. It also has political implications. If culture is regarded as embedded in social interaction, that is, as something that is socially produced and reproduced over time, influencing people's behaviour in relation to the use of language, technology,

rules and laws, and knowledge and ideas (including ideas about legitimate authority and leadership), then it cannot be discovered or mechanically manipulated; it can only be described and interpreted. The researcher adopting the social emergent view of culture cannot suggest how it can be created or destroyed; the researcher can only attempt to record and examine how culture may be altered in the process of social reproduction. People do not just passively absorb meanings and symbols; they produce and reproduce culture, and in the process of reproducing it, they may transform it. The social emergent approach to culture also moves the researcher away from the political and ideological interests of management, towards those of the organizational community as a whole.

While it seems necessary to consider culture as something that an organization 'is', rather than something that it 'has' this still begs the question of how (or if) culture is to be demarcated from other social aspects of the organization. The basic question is whether to adopt an inclusive use of the term 'culture' in the tradition of Tylor ([1871] 1958), or to distinguish culture from social structure?

The debate between those theorists who view culture as meshed into the social system and those who view it as a conceptually distinct ideational system is not confined to organizational studies. It is a debate which has raged in social anthropology over several decades (Singer 1968: 528).

Social theory which adopts an inclusive view of culture 'tacitly assumes that the social and structural components are (must be) fully integrated, synchronized and consonant with the ideational, symbolic dimensions of the organization' (Allaire and Firsirotu 1984: 199). One of the problems with this approach to culture is that it does not take account of shifts in the social structure which may occur in the absence of corresponding shifts in members' norms, values and ideologies. Another problem with the inclusive view of culture is that it denies the possibility of conflict between the ideas, ideologies and values of organizational members and the organization's structure (formal and informal). There is evidence to suggest not only that such conflict may exist, but also that it can be an essential feature of an organization. For example, in a case study of an Australian College of Advanced Education, it was concluded that:

'When structures . . . are thought to be in conflict with basic academic norms . . . disputes of an ideological nature will follow. This form of conflict can rapidly become intractable, with participants basing their actions upon opposing sets of values and finding it extremely difficult to communicate with each other. Structural change within [the College] proceeded in the absence of due consideration for the normative nature of the enterprise. . . . Severe and protracted conflict was the result.' (Meek 1984: 130-131)

On a broader scale, it also seems necessary to draw a distinction between culture and structure in order to address the question of how the structure of 'class cultures' in the wider society may cut across individual organizations (see Turner 1986).

For the purposes of analysis and interpretation, it seems necessary to distinguish between culture and social structure, but in so doing, two factors must be kept firmly in mind. First, culture and structure are two sides of the same coin: they are parallel and complementary and constantly interacting with one another:

'One of the more useful ways — but far from the only one — of distinguishing between culture and social system is to see the former as an ordered system of meaning and of symbols, in terms of which social interaction takes place; and to see the latter as the pattern of social interaction itself. . . .' (Geertz 1973: 144)

Second, both culture and structure are abstractions, not tangible entities:

'The difference between the two concepts is not that one is an abstraction and the other a concrete, observable unit of behaviour, for both are abstractions of regularities from observations of actual behaviour, whether these regularities are implicit and unconscious or explicit and verbalized.' (Singer 1968: 533)

The task for the researcher in the field is not to observe culture or structure, but to observe the concrete behaviour of individual actors. Culture and social structure are not concrete entities, rather they are abstract concepts that are to be used to interpret behaviour. Geertz's (1973: 5) definition of culture clearly focusses the attention of the researcher on concrete behaviour: 'Believing, with Max Weber, that man is an animal suspended in webs of significance he himself has spun, I take culture to be those webs, and the analysis of it to be therefore not an experimental science in search of law but an interpretive one in search of meaning'.

The task of the social scientist is to observe and describe the actions of human beings and their characterizations of social reality: social science is the researcher's constructions of the layman's constructions of what he and his compatriots are up to (Geertz 1973: 9). While culture is the webs of significance spun by man, structure is also the medium and the product of social interaction:

'[Structures] are both the medium and the outcome of interaction. They are the medium, because structures provide the rules and resources individuals must draw on to interact meaningfully. They are its outcome, because rules and resources exist only through being applied and acknowledged in interaction — they have no reality independent of the social practices they constitute' (Riley 1983: 415)

So far it has been argued that while there is a symbiotic relationship between culture and social structure, in analysis, the researcher needs to draw a distinction between the two concepts. However, this still leaves the problem of how to approach 'culture' in empirical research. 'Culture', as a holistic concept, is far too broad to be the main thrust on any research agenda; the concept needs to be dissected into manageable proportions.

The Dissection of Culture

Most anthropological studies contain one or more of the following 'cultural derivatives': symbol (including language, architecture and artifacts), myth, ideational systems (including ideology), and ritual. While anthropologists and sociologists continue to debate the 'proper' uses and meanings of these concepts, most studies approach them in terms of what motivates individuals and groups to action (Silverman 1970). There is no space here to discuss each concept in detail. Rather, a brief definition of each will be provided — keeping in mind the preceding argument that culture is neither necessarily an adaptive regulatory mechanism, nor does it necessarily unite individuals and groups into social structures — and some hints on how they may be used in analysis will be offered.

Symbol is the most inclusive of the various cultural derivatives, 'not only because language, ritual, and myth are forms of symbolism but because symbolic analysis is a form of reference, a style of analysis in its own right' (Pettigrew 1979: 575). Symbols are shared codes of meaning and include a variety of things — words, stories, icons, organizational logos or national flags — that provide 'meanings, evoke emotions, and impel men [and women] to action' (Cohen 1974: 23). Language is a representation, a symbol, of the real thing. Organizations may be distinguished by the language their members use: academics use jargon to mystify knowledge and computer programmers use a language that mystifies everyone but themselves. The guard tower is a symbol of both the concentration camp and the modern prison, impelling individuals to a form of negative action. Religious icons may, on the one hand, unite the faithful, and on the other, lead them to scourge the infidel.

Organization has itself been defined as being nothing more or less than patterns of symbolic discourse. Within the phenomenology, symbolic interactionism and ethnomethodology schools:

'organizations become figments of participants' interpretation of their organizational experience; they have no external reality but are merely social creations and construction emerging from actors making sense out of ongoing streams of actions and interactions. In what Burrell and Morgan (1979: 260) call their interpretive paradigm, "organizations simply do not exist".' (Allaire and Firsirotu 1984: 208)

This approach to organizational analysis is in danger of collapsing the social organizational and cultural components of social life into one unitary concept. As argued above, there is a need to maintain a conceptual distinction between culture and social structure, particularly for the purposes of investigating change and conflict. When the sociostructural pattern of human organization is collapsed into being solely a pattern of symbolic discourse, 'the dynamic elements in social change which arise from the failure of cultural patterns to be perfectly congruent with forms of social organization are largely incapable of formation' (Geertz 1957: 992)

An organization is, of course, a structured association of individuals, and it is

individuals who create meanings and symbols. Organization cannot be reduced to the individual, for to do so misinterprets the significance, and the power, of organization. MacIntyre puts the case in relation to the military organization thus:

'You cannot characterise an army by referring to the soldiers who belong to it. For to do that you have to identify them as soldiers; and to do that is already to bring in the concept of an army. For a soldier just is an individual who belongs to an army. Thus we see that the characterisation of individuals and of classes [or organizations] has to go together. Essentially these are not two separate tasks.' (quoted in Thompson 1978: 30)

Certainly, symbols are worthy of the researcher's attention. If the symbolic mode of interpretation is to consider the dynamics of change and conflict, then it seems that symbols need to be analyzed in terms of a 'dialogue' between actors' sets of meanings and other social organizational aspects of the institution.

Closely related to the idea of culture as patterns of symbolic discourse is the notion of culture as ideational or cognitive systems, i.e., cultures seen as systems of knowledge (Keesing 1974). One of the main proponents of this stance in anthropology is Goodenough:

'A society's culture consists of whatever it is one has to know or believe in order to operate in a manner acceptable to its members. Culture is not a material phenomenon: it does not consist of things, people, behavior, or emotions. It is rather an organization of these things. It is the form of things that people have in mind, their models for perceiving, relating, and otherwise interpreting them.' (quoted in Keesing 1974: 77)

Obviously, men and women must share some knowledge in common in order to act in concert: organized work would be impossible if people did not share some meanings, knowledge systems and symbols. 'Most occupations . . . operate on the premise that the people who work in them know certain procedures and certain ways of thinking about and responding to typical situations and problems' (Becker 1982: 522). However, like symbolic interactionism, the ideational or cognitive theory of organizational culture fails when it is elevated to a universal theory that attempts to explain all social organizational phenomena. 'Analyses of cultures as cognitive systems have not progressed very far beyond a mapping of limited and neatly bonded semantic domains' (Keesing 1974: 78). Organizational culture is too rich and diverse to be amenable to a comprehensive interpretation through ideational codes, however sophisticated their elaboration.

However, the investigation of cognitive systems can be a powerful analytical tool so long as the interpretation of ideas and knowledge is related to, but kept separate from, social structural issues. It is here that the concept of ideology may play an important role. Ideology is not only 'a set of beliefs about the social world and how it operates', but also contains ethical statements 'about the rightness of certain social arrangements' (Wilson 1973: 91). An ideology may be congruent with the social structure, or it may be expressly divergent from the

pattern of social interaction within the organization. Also, an organization may contain a number of ideologies, with ideological groupings in competition with one another over such issues as power and legitimate authority. These are, of course, empirical questions that can be answered only through research.

Contrary to the popular lay definition, myth is not regarded by anthropologists as an erroneous story. Rather, 'a myth is a narrative of events; the narrative has a sacred quality; the sacred communication is made in symbolic form; at least some of the events and objects which occur in the myth neither occur nor exist in the world other than that of myth itself; and the narrative refers in dramatic form to origins or transformations' (Cohen 1969: 337). Organizational myths or stories certainly do not constitute all that is 'cultural' in an organization, but the interpretation of organization members' myths and folklores is one angle of attack on the problem of organizational culture that has proved to be fruitful. Creation myths are usually thought of as something belonging to traditional societies, but members of modern organizations also have their stories about how the organization came into being and how it developed over time. Clark terms such folk stories or myths 'organizational sagas':

'Saga . . . has come to mean a narrative of heroic exploits, of a unique development that has deeply stirred the emotions of participants and descendants. Thus, a saga is not simply a story but a story that at some time has had a particular base of believers . . .'

(Clark 1972: 178–179)

The notion of an organizational saga is a useful theoretical tool for the study of certain aspects of symbolic behaviour. As a concept it gives importance to publicly expressed stories about group uniqueness; it is an explanation of what makes an organization unique and distinctive in the eyes of its members. In theory, these stories or 'folk histories' may function as symbolic justifications for members' actions in concrete situations.

Martin et al. (1983: 439), while recognizing the emphasis on uniqueness in organizational stories and sagas, maintain that there are also 'similarities in content and structure' in all such stories: 'a culture's claim to uniqueness is expressed through cultural manifestations that are not in fact unique. This is the uniqueness paradox'. Anthropologists, such as Malinowski, Levi-Strauss, and others, have also looked at the creation myths of different traditional societies in order to discover similarities in content and structure.

It also needs to be recognized that myths, folklores and sagas may be a source of conflict, particularly in the context of rapid social change. There is evidence to suggest that at least one organization's saga, while appropriate to the development of the institution during a particular historical period, became quite inappropriate and caused disunity, following dramatic changes in the institution's external political environment (Meek 1982). In another study (Meek 1984), it was argued that the organization had developed two sets of shared beliefs and ideologies that were in competition with one another: a saga and a counter-saga.

All organizations have forms of ritualized behaviour. A university, for

example, would not be a university without the ritual and symbols that surround such events as graduation ceremonies and inaugural lectures. The ritual is as old as the idea of the university itself. At graduation, academics and graduands clothe themselves in medieval garb and speak in foreign tongues — Latin. The procession preceding an inaugural lecture is led by the bearer of arms carrying a mace. Except for historians, most members of the university organization have long forgotten the origin and function of such cultural artifacts as the academic gown and mace, but they all know that these artifacts symbolize the university, and they share a feeling of belonging to an academic community whenever the artifacts are displayed and the ritual is performed.

According to Benedict (1934: 396), ritual simply is the 'prescribed formal behaviour for occasions not given over to technological routine'. This definition is attractive in its simplicity, although it leaves the question of how rituals are to be interpreted unanswered. Anthropologists (Beattie 1966) and organizational theorists (Pettigrew 1979) often maintain that what is important is what rituals 'say' not what they 'do'. In this sense, Harrison, (1951) maintained that 'ritual is a dramatization of myth'. However, Leach (1968: 524) argues that 'ritual may "do things" as well as "say things"'. The most obvious examples are healing rituals which form a vast class and have a world-wide distribution'. Ritualized physical exercise in Japanese industries is both an expression of corporate allegiance and a mechanism for maintaining the health of the workforce.

It is often assumed that rituals legitimate established authority, and 'provide a shared experience of belonging and express and reinforce what is valued' (Pettigrew 1979: 576). However, as Gluckman (1962) has shown, 'rituals of rebellion' may have the opposite function: they allow people to act out hostilities that may not be expressed in normal everyday social relations.

The interpretation of ritual is just as complicated as any other aspect of cultural behaviour. However, research into the ritualization of behaviour should not assume from the outset that ritual expresses and sanctifies the established social order. It may do this, but ritual may also be a mechanism for maintaining one group in power despite the will of others, or it may be a dramatized expression of rebellion of one group against others. Once again, these are empirical questions, not something that can be assumed through theory.

Summary

There has been a tendency for some researchers to treat organizational culture as a 'variable' that can be controlled and manipulated like any other organizational variable. Culture *as a whole* cannot be manipulated, turned on and off, although it needs to be recognized that some are in a better position than others to attempt to intentionally influence aspects of it. The tendency to assume otherwise results, at least in part, from the selective way in which the

concept of culture has been borrowed from anthropology and sociology. The basis of the argument presented in this paper is that culture should be regarded as something that an organization 'is', not as something that an organization 'has': it is not an independent variable, nor can it be created, discovered or destroyed by the whims of management. Nonetheless, it seems necessary for the purposes of the interpretation of actors' behaviour, that a conceptual distinction be made between 'culture' and 'social structure'. It must be kept in mind, though, that both culture and structure are abstractions, and have use only in relation to the interpretation of observed concrete behaviour. This paper, however, does not advance any one elaborate or steadfast theoretical model of cultural interpretation; for 'it is going to take more than one kind of theoretical model to do justice to the variety, complexity, and richness of human culture' (Singer 1968: 541).

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